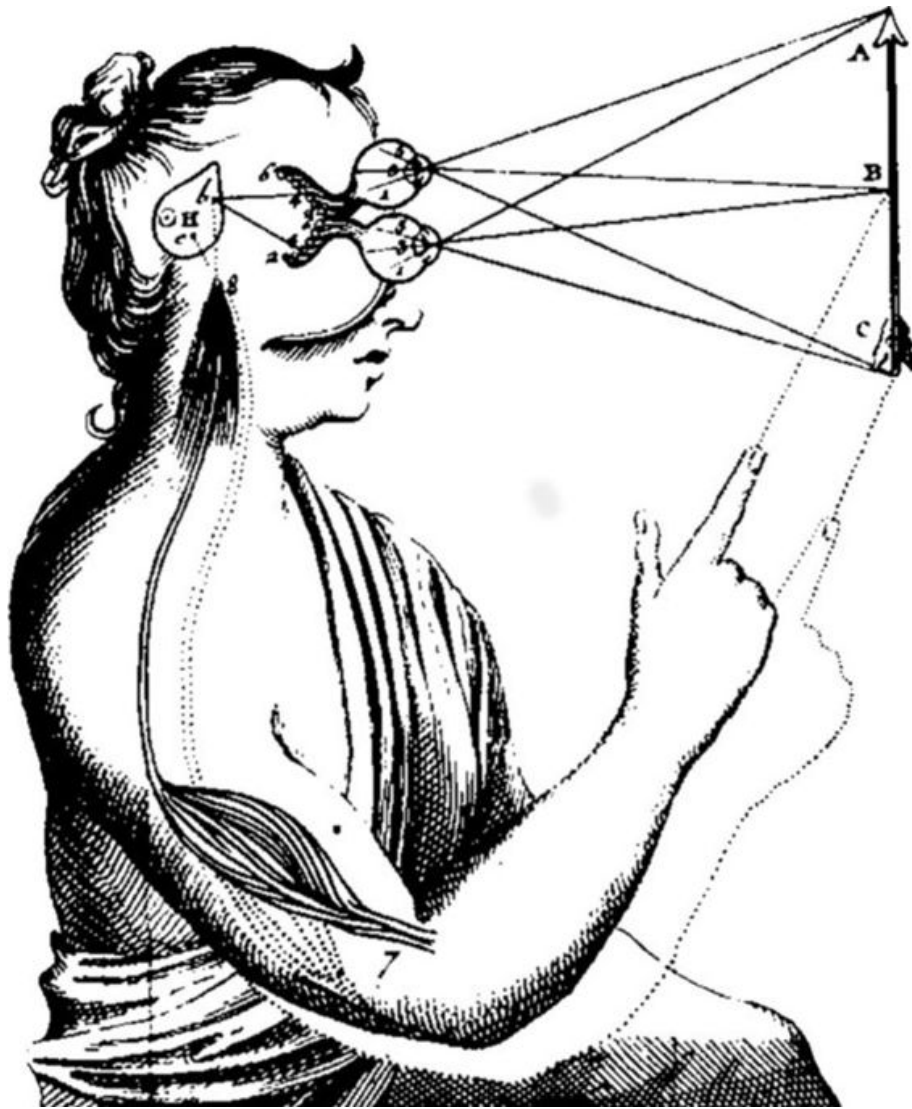


Mind-body dualism



Descartes believed the senses carried information to the brain, where it was passed to an immaterial spirit or mind.

In establishing '*Cogito, ergo sum*' as a First Certainty to work from, Descartes implicitly identifies himself as a thinking being. The 'I' of 'I think, therefore I am' is the part that thinks, distinct from the physical senses that can be deceived. From this, he inferred that the mind, the 'thinking thing', is not only separate from the body, but is of a fundamentally different substance. This belief, so-called mind-body

dualism, was not new – many classical philosophers believed in the existence of a ‘psyche’ independent of the body, and most religions also believed in a realm inhabited by immortal souls – but Descartes was the first to present the case in a systematic way.

The distinctions made in this ‘substantive dualism’, that our bodies are made of a physical, material substance and our minds of a mental, immaterial substance, extended to the outside world. Humans, because they are capable of reasoning, have minds as well as physical bodies. Things that cannot reason do not have minds and so only exist as material objects.